

Module 2.1: Data Collection and Analysis

Table of Contents

Aspects of Method Validation	1
Observation & Methods of Data Collection	1
Sampling.....	2
Errors.....	3
1. Sampling Errors	3
2. Non-Sampling Errors	3
Sampling Methods.....	4
A. Probability Sampling (Random Selection)	4
B. Non-Probability Sampling (Non-Random Selection)	5
Data Processing and Analysis Strategies and Tools.....	5

Aspects of Method Validation

- 1. Importance of Validation in Research:** Validation ensures that research findings are reliable, accurate, and applicable. Key reasons for validation:
 - **Accuracy:** Confirms data correctness and minimizes errors.
 - **Reliability:** Ensures results are consistent under repeated trials.
 - **Generalizability:** Helps apply findings to a broader population.
 - **Credibility:** Enhances the authenticity of research for academic and professional use.
- 2. Validation Techniques**
 - **Internal Validation:**
 - **Reproducibility:** Checking if results remain consistent when repeated.
 - **Cross-validation:** Splitting data into training and testing sets to check model accuracy.
 - **Pilot Testing:** Conducting a small-scale study before full research.
 - **External Validation:**
 - **Peer Review:** Getting feedback from experts.
 - **Comparison with Existing Data:** Ensuring consistency with previous research.
 - **Triangulation:** Using multiple methods to validate results.

Observation & Methods of Data Collection

Observation: Observation involves gathering data by watching subjects in their natural setting. Common methods:

- **Structured Observation:** Pre-defined criteria; used in scientific studies.
- **Unstructured Observation:** No predefined criteria; flexible and exploratory.
- **Participant Observation:** Researcher actively engages in the group being observed.
- **Non-Participant Observation:** Researcher observes without direct involvement.
- **Direct Observation:** Watching events in real-time.
- **Indirect Observation:** Analyzing past records, videos, or footprints of activities

1. Surveys

- A structured method to collect data from a large population.
- Can be conducted via **online forms, phone calls, or face-to-face interactions**.
- **Advantages:** Cost-effective, quick, and scalable.
- **Disadvantages:** Response bias, low participation rates.

2. Interviews

- **Face-to-face or virtual conversations** to collect in-depth data.
- Types:
 - **Structured:** Predefined questions, no deviation.
 - **Semi-structured:** Mix of predefined and open-ended questions.
 - **Unstructured:** Free-flowing, conversational.
- **Advantages:** Detailed responses, clarifications possible.
- **Disadvantages:** Time-consuming, interviewer bias.

3. Questionnaires

- A set of written questions to gather specific information.
- Can be **open-ended (descriptive) or close-ended (MCQs, Likert scale, etc.)**.
- **Advantages:** Easy to analyze, standardized.
- **Disadvantages:** Limited depth, non-serious responses.

4. Case Studies

- **In-depth analysis** of a single entity (individual, group, or organization).
- Uses **qualitative & quantitative** data.
- **Advantages:** Deep understanding, real-life context.
- **Disadvantages:** Time-consuming, difficult to generalize findings.

5. Experiments

- Conducting tests under **controlled conditions** to examine cause-and-effect relationships.
- **Advantages:** High accuracy, reproducible.
- **Disadvantages:** Artificial setting may not reflect real-life scenarios.

Sampling

Sampling is the process of selecting a subset (sample) from a larger group (population) to draw conclusions about the whole group, while saving time, effort, and cost. Steps in sampling design:

1. **Objective of Study:** Define the main goal of the research and what you intend to learn or estimate from the sample. **Example:** To study the average study hours of engineering students.
2. **Define the Population:** Clearly identify the entire group from which the sample will be drawn. **Example:** All 3rd-year engineering students in India.
3. **Specify the Sampling Frame:** List or source that contains all elements of the population (ideally complete and updated). **Example:** Enrollment records from AICTE-accredited colleges.
4. **Determine the Sampling Unit:** The basic unit considered for sampling—could be individuals, households, schools, etc. **Example:** One student is one sampling unit.

5. **Decide on Sample Size:** Choose how many units will be selected, balancing accuracy with available resources. **Depends on:** Population size, variability, confidence level, margin of error.
6. **Identify Parameters of Interest:** Decide what you're measuring from the sample—mean, proportion, standard deviation, etc. **Example:** Average hours of study per day.
7. **Select the Sampling Method/Design:** Choose a sampling technique based on research purpose and feasibility:
 - a. **Probability Sampling:** Simple random, stratified, cluster, systematic
 - b. **Non-Probability Sampling:** Convenience, quota, judgmental, snowball
8. **Plan Data Collection:** Decide how, when, and from whom you will collect data. Methods: Surveys, interviews, online forms, observations, etc.
9. **Check for Sampling Bias or Errors:** Evaluate whether the sample represents the population fairly. Apply corrective measures if needed. Watch out for:
 - c. **Selection bias**
 - d. **Non-response bias**
 - e. **Undercoverage or overcoverage**

Errors

1. Sampling Errors

Errors that occur **because only a subset** (sample) of the population is studied, **not the entire population**. **Example:** If you survey 100 students from only 2 colleges to estimate average study time for all students in India, your result may not reflect the whole population accurately. **Causes:**

- Natural variation between sample and population
- Improper sampling technique
- Small or biased sample size

Can be reduced by:

- Increasing sample size
- Using probability sampling techniques (e.g., stratified or random sampling)

2. Non-Sampling Errors

Errors that occur **regardless of sampling**, due to problems in the data collection or analysis process.

Example: data entry errors, biased survey questions, error in data analysis, false information. **Types:**

- **Response Error:** Respondent lies or misunderstands question
- **Non-Response Error:** Some participants don't respond
- **Data Processing Error:** Mistakes in data entry, coding, or analysis
- **Measurement Error:** Use of faulty instruments or unclear questions
- **Interviewer Bias:** Interviewer's tone or wording influences responses

Can be reduced by:

- Better questionnaire design
- Proper training of enumerators/interviewers
- Pre-testing surveys
- Automated data entry and cleaning tools

Point	Sampling Error	Non-Sampling Error
Cause	Using a sample, not full population	Data collection or processing mistakes
Where	Only in sample surveys	In both sample and census
Control	Better sampling methods	Better tools and training
Example	Sample mean $\neq$ population mean	Wrong info given or typed

Sampling Methods

A. Probability Sampling (Random Selection)

- Every individual has an equal, known, non-zero chance of selection.
- Sample size is very large.
- Reduces bias and increases generalizability.
- Ensures representativeness.
- Allows statistical inference about the population.
- Supports calculation of sampling errors and confidence intervals.

1. Simple Random Sampling (SRS): Every individual has an **equal chance** of being selected.

- **How it works:** Use random number tables, computer-generated random numbers, or lottery methods.
- **Example:** Randomly picking 100 students from a university roster of 1,000 students.
- **Pros:** Simple, unbiased, easy to analyze statistically.
- **Cons:** Can be impractical with large populations; may not capture population diversity well.

2. Systematic Sampling: Select every kth member from a **sorted list** after choosing a random starting point.

- **How it works:** If you want 100 samples from 1,000, pick every 10th person after randomly selecting a start between 1 and 10.
- **Example:** Surveying every 5th visitor entering a mall.
- **Pros:** Simple, easy to implement, ensures even spread.
- **Cons:** Can introduce bias if there's a hidden pattern in the list.

3. Stratified Sampling: Population divided into **homogeneous subgroups (strata)** based on a characteristic; random samples taken from each stratum.

- **How it works:** Separate students by major, then randomly sample from each major proportionally.
- **Example:** dividing Kolkata into north, central, south Kolkata and randomly choosing few schools from each area.
- **Pros:** More precise, ensures representation of all groups.
- **Cons:** Requires detailed population info upfront; more complex.

4. Cluster Sampling: Population divided into **clusters (usually geographic or organizational units)**; some clusters are randomly selected (all clusters are not selected like stratified sampling where all strata are selected), and all or some members within those clusters are sampled.

- **How it works:** assume there are 10 districts we randomly select 2 schools each from 5 of those districts, then survey all students in those schools.
- **Pros:** Cost-effective and practical for large, spread-out populations.
- **Cons:** Higher sampling error if clusters are heterogeneous internally but differ from each other.

5. Multi-stage Sampling: Combines several sampling methods, usually starting with cluster sampling, then applying another method like stratified or random sampling within clusters.

- **How it works:** Select districts randomly (clusters), then households within districts by random sampling.
- **Example:** National health surveys on households often use multi-stage sampling. First stage unit maybe states, second stage may be district then village, then building then household.

- **Pros:** Flexible, balances cost and accuracy.
- **Cons:** Complex design, requires careful planning and analysis.

B. Non-Probability Sampling (Non-Random Selection)

- Biased selection method based on researcher's judgment, convenience, or other criteria, not random.
- Sample size is small.
- Used when probability sampling is not feasible.
- Quicker and more **cost-effective**.
- Good for **exploratory or qualitative research**.
- Helps study **hard-to-reach or specialized populations**.

1. Convenience Sampling: Samples are selected based on **ease of access**.

- **How it works:** Survey whoever is nearby or willing to participate.
- **Example:** Polling students outside the library because they're easy to reach.
- **Pros:** Quick, inexpensive, easy to implement.
- **Cons:** High risk of bias, not representative.

2. Judgmental (Purposive) Sampling: Researcher uses **expert judgment** to select subjects deemed most useful.

- **How it works:** Choose participants who have specific knowledge or experience relevant to the study.
- **Example:** If I want to know how many farmers took loan > 5 lakhs from bank, I need to contact the bank manager for this information.
- **Pros:** Targeted, efficient for specialized topics.
- **Cons:** Subjective, high potential for bias.

3. Quota Sampling: Population is divided into groups (like strata), but sampling within groups is **non-random** to meet a quota.

- **How it works:** Interview 50 men and 50 women, but pick respondents based on convenience within these groups.
- **Example:** Market research ensuring equal gender representation by approaching shoppers in a mall.
- **Pros:** Ensures group representation, faster than probability stratified sampling.
- **Cons:** Non-random, so bias remains.

4. Snowball Sampling: Existing study subjects recruit future participants from among their acquaintances.

- **How it works:** Start with a few known individuals and see if they are to be selected and then ask them to refer others to know if they can be selected.
- In this way the sample group grows like a rolling snowball.
- **Example:** Studying underground communities or hard-to-reach populations like drug users.
- **Pros:** Useful for hidden or rare populations.
- **Cons:** Can lead to sampling bias, as social networks are often homogeneous.

Data Processing and Analysis Strategies and Tools

1. Data Cleaning and Processing: Before analysis, raw data must be cleaned and processed to ensure accuracy.

Steps in Data Cleaning:

- **Handling Missing Data:** Removing or imputing missing values.
- **Removing Duplicates:** Identifying and eliminating redundant entries.
- **Correcting Errors:** Fixing incorrect data entries.

- **Normalization:** Standardizing data formats.
- **Data Transformation:** Converting data into a suitable format (e.g., numerical encoding for categorical variables).

2. Tools for Data Analysis

Common tools used for data analysis include:

- **Excel:** Basic statistical analysis, pivot tables, and visualization.
- **Python (Pandas, NumPy, SciPy):** For advanced statistical and machine learning applications.
- **R:** A statistical computing language for in-depth analysis.
- **SQL:** Querying and analyzing structured data.

3. Software for Data Analysis

Several software tools assist in data analysis:

- **SPSS (Statistical Package for the Social Sciences)** – Used for statistical tests and regression analysis.
- **SigmaStat** – A statistical analysis tool with built-in tests.
- **MATLAB** – Used for numerical computing and data visualization.
- **SAS (Statistical Analysis System)** – Handles large-scale data analysis.
- **Stata** – Used in social science research for econometrics and statistics.